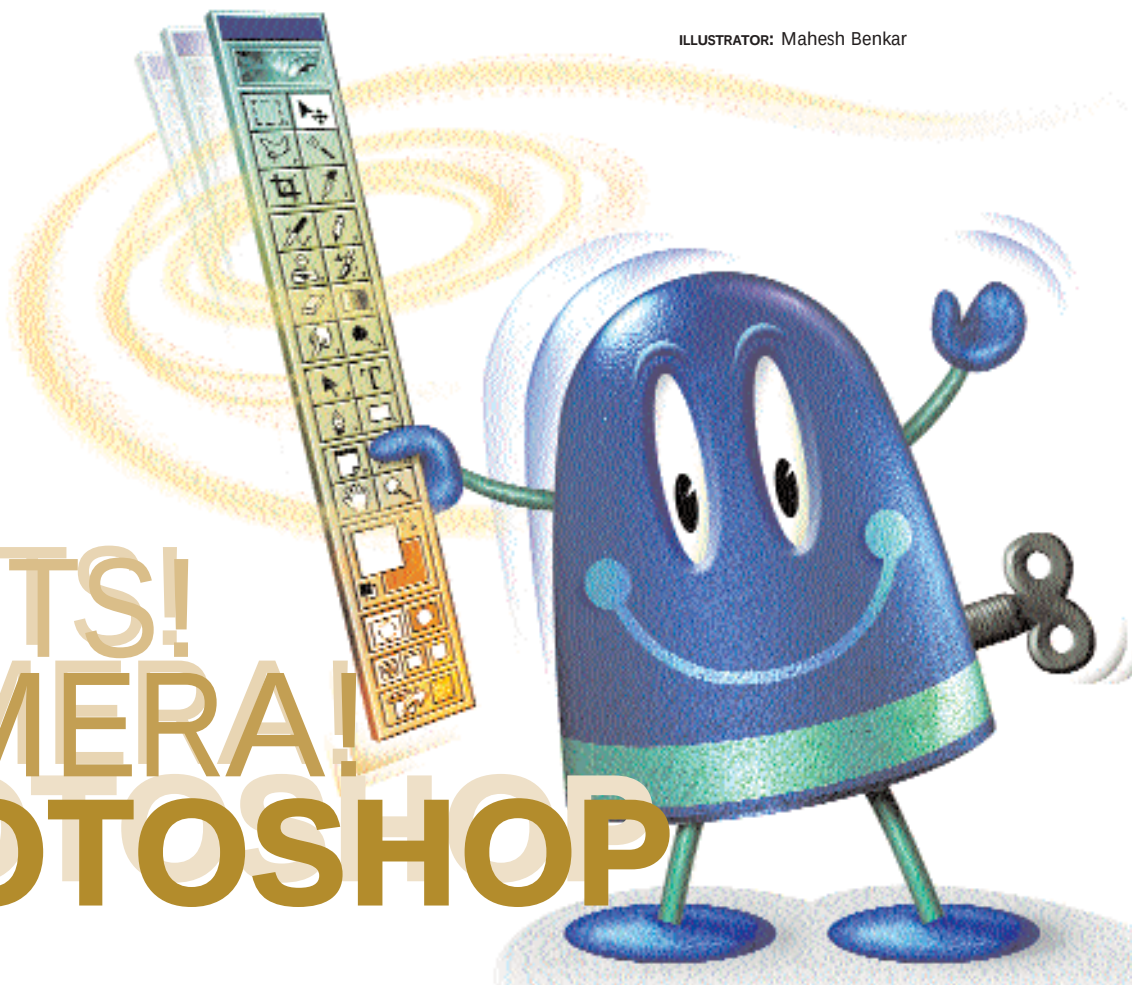


LIGHTS! CAMERA! PHOTOSHOP



Use Actions in Photoshop to save sets of commands for a more efficient image editing experience

Action! No, this isn't some director shouting on a movie set. This is a tool in Photoshop that lets you accumulate a series of commands into a single action. Say, you have devised a way to give your text an 'exploding' look. Unfortunately, this involves 18 steps and commands, and there's no way you will remember all 18, leave alone in the order of execution, the next time you want this effect. This is where actions help, all you need to do is record your actions and then play them back on any text to get the same effect.

So what are actions? An action is a series of commands that can be played back on a single file or a batch of files. It can be compared with macros in Microsoft Word. Actions are the most important aspect of automating work in Photoshop. All other automate commands, directly or indirectly, depend upon actions. For example, an action can be created to change an image into a thumbnail, followed by the Outer Bevel command to give it a button-like look, and a Save command that saves the file in a specified format. The best part is once you define an action, it can be

applied to any number of files, as many times as you like.

You can record almost any command and tool operation as an action. Photoshop comes with many predefined actions and more can be downloaded from the Internet, (*See box, 'Sites to Visit'*). All actions are accessible from the Actions palette.

Most tasks related to actions are performed using the Actions palette. This palette can be turned on and off by pressing [F9] or by going to **Window > Actions**. There are two modes in which the palette is displayed: the List mode and the Button mode. In the default List mode, sets, actions and commands can be collapsed and expanded. To do this, click the triangle to the left of the set, or action, in the Actions palette. If [Alt] is kept pressed while clicking the triangle, all actions in that set, or all commands in that action are expanded or collapsed. If the name of the action is clicked, that particular action is selected.

Recording... please wait!

Before you begin recording actions, remember that actions recorded for a par-

ticular file might not yield the same result on another—for example, a 3-pixel Gaussian blur won't create the same effect on a 72-ppi file as on a 144-ppi file. Also remember that when recording actions that include dialog box and palette settings, only the changed settings are recorded. Since the tools that record position use the units currently specified by the ruler, it is a good idea to set the ruler units to per cent. This helps while applying actions to files of different sizes.

To create a new action, open a file. In the Actions palette, click New Action, or choose New Action from the palette menu that pops up when you click the triangle at the top right corner of the palette. In the dialog box that pops up, enter a name for the action. Assign a keyboard shortcut and a colour—for the action to be displayed in Button mode—if you want. Now press Record and the Record button in the Actions palette turns red. Whatever commands and operations are performed now, will be recorded in the action. Press Stop when you're done. While using the **File > Save As...** command, do not change